
UNCOMMON SCHOOLS

Media Agency Request For Proposal
May 2025

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I. Introduction and Background

1.1 Introduction

[Uncommon Schools](#) is a non-profit network of 52 outstanding public charter schools in grades K-12 across New York, New Jersey, and Massachusetts. Our mission is to start and manage outstanding urban public charter schools that close the opportunity gap and prepare students from low-income backgrounds for success in college and beyond.

Years ago, the demand for and opening of Charter schools and networks saw consistent growth. In recent years, however, that growth has slowed. Charter schools and networks have faced challenges due to several factors, including (but not limited to) reduced teacher (staff) talent as fewer graduates enter teacher training programs, new (charter) entrants filling the category, demographic shifts as families are priced out of urban areas and relocating to new cities or states, and reduced student population as Millennials have children later and less often.

As the competition for students and staff intensifies, we require effective, innovative, and data-driven paid media strategies that set us apart in a mature, crowded category.

1.2 About Uncommon Schools

For over 25 years, Uncommon Schools has been making education history by sending thousands of first-generation students to and through college. We provide outstanding PreK-12 education and the joyful, rigorous environment that students deserve to succeed in college and on their path to economic freedom. Our track record of graduating students from college at five times the rate of their peers is unequalled. We have pioneered and shared America's best data-driven instructional methods, systems, and practices, registering an impact far exceeding our size.

Since our founding, we have scaled educational excellence to close the opportunity gap in economically disadvantaged communities. Our proven academic results make us the model for the best schools in the U.S. and worldwide. Not only do our students pass AP exams at twice the national average, but they also graduate from college at five times the rate of their peers. Our PreK-12 program helps students discover and develop their passions and voices, building their confidence and self-awareness. At Uncommon, we see and love our students for who they are and for who they can become. We welcome all students and meet them where they are while equipping them to pursue their dreams through college and beyond.

Uncommon Schools by the Numbers

- 25-year history (we're pioneers in the space)
- 5 regions: [Brooklyn](#) and [Rochester](#), NY; [Newark](#) and [Camden](#), NJ; and [Boston](#), MA
- 20,000 students
- 52 schools serving Pre-K through 12th grade
- 85% of students are considered economically disadvantaged
- 70% of staff identify as people of color

1.3 Project Overview

This Request for Proposal (RFP) will help us identify a media planning agency that can effectively support our organization in achieving our marketing and communication goals. We seek a partner who understands our unique brand, target audience, and market dynamics.

The selected agency will develop, execute, and regularly optimize a comprehensive paid media strategy aligned with our business objectives. This includes conducting thorough market research, identifying optimal media channels, and creating innovative campaigns to enhance our brand visibility and engagement.

Our ideal partner will possess a proven track record of success in media planning, demonstrate creative thinking, and offer insights into emerging trends in the media landscape. We seek a collaborative partnership fostering open communication, transparency, and flexibility.

1.4 Objectives and Goals

We are actively developing Uncommon's five-year strategic plans to re-establish our credibility and perception as the leader of the nation's best and highest-performing PK-12 schools. Our goals include closing the college completion gap, providing a path to economic freedom as one of the largest school systems in the country, and continuing to impact students nationally (and around the world !).

We are looking for a strong agency partner to support us in achieving our 5-year ambitions, with our Marketing function laser-focused on these objectives:

- **Enhance Brand Awareness & Perception:** Increase brand visibility and positive perceptions among current and prospective families and teachers.
Goal: Achieve a 40% increase in high-quality leads for both teacher recruitment and student enrollment over the next five years, utilizing impactful media campaigns that establish Uncommon as the gold standard in charter education.
- **Drive Enrollment & Retention:** Strengthen our recruitment strategies to ensure complete enrollment across all schools.
Goal: Attain over 95% enrollment capacity for new schools and ensure 85% year-over-year persistence rates in every region by 2030.
- **Measure & Optimize Campaign Effectiveness:** Implement a robust measurement framework to evaluate campaign performance.
Goal: Establish a real-time analytics dashboard within the first year of engagement, with a demonstrable improvement in media spending efficiency and reporting clarity by 20% within the first two years.

1.5 Target Audience

Audience

Parents of preK-12 students
PreK-12 teachers and operations staff

Markets

Brooklyn, Rochester, Camden, Newark, Boston

Demographics

- Parent Audience: Typically Black, Hispanic, Low/Moderate Income with school-aged children, particularly children aged 5-15
- Teacher Audience: College Degree Required, Master's Degree Optional; Career-changers (current K-12 teachers in DOE, other charter schools), recent college graduates

1.6 Current Paid Media Tactics

We currently run paid media campaigns to support our efforts in growing brand awareness, strengthening brand perception, and recruiting students and teaching staff. Our current media strategy leverages channels and tactics across the Paid, Owned, and Earned media spectrum.

Current channels include:

Paid	Owned	Earned
Meta*		
Google Search	Social Media (FB, IG, YT, LinkedIn)	
Google Ad Grant**	Website	
YouTube / Streaming TV	Email/CRM	News media coverage (often featuring student success stories)
Streaming audio	OOH (via owned school buildings)	Placement of Uncommon-authored pieces/Op-Eds
Programmatic web ads		
Out of Home		
Direct Mail		
Email Marketing	<u>Non-Traditional:</u>	
Indeed	School Uniforms	
LinkedIn		

*Meta paid includes traditional paid Instagram/Facebook ads, as well as boosting of organic Instagram posts, for which the budget is not incorporated into our general paid media dollars.

**We receive \$10,000 in Google Ad Grant dollars per month from Google for paid search ads, which can be used as needed; these dollars follow different rules from typical paid search ads. **

We have also made adjustments to our media strategy to optimize our efforts and spending. We are running tests to distribute investment more effectively throughout the year, leveraging the natural seasonality of prospective family and staff behaviors. Additionally, we have begun to increase our investment in and tactics used to support general Awareness media. Ideally, we would like to strengthen the way these channels work together, in tandem, to share a consistent and cohesive story and support overall awareness and consideration goals.

1.7 Challenges and Opportunities

Our multifaceted approach supports our efforts to connect with prospective families and staff when and where they are. While we have continued to test and refine our media strategy, we still face significant challenges and exciting opportunities to strengthen and optimize it.

Some of the challenges that we face include:

- **Limited Awareness:** Despite efforts, brand visibility remains lower than desired in certain regions, hindering enrollment.
- **Resource Allocation:** Budget constraints have reduced investment in key media channels, limiting reach and engagement.
- **Audience Engagement:** Difficulty in effectively reaching and engaging target audiences, particularly underserved communities.
- **Measurement & Optimization:** Inadequate tools for real-time analytics have made it challenging to measure campaign effectiveness and adjust strategies promptly.
- **Attribution:** Difficulty in measuring attribution across all marketing channels and through the entire user journey to understand the ROI of marketing investment
- **Messaging Consistency:** Advertising to two distinct audiences and within five different markets (prospective students and families, and prospective instructional staff) presents a challenge in maintaining a consistent overall brand story. Balancing the different aims of attracting enrollments while recruiting quality staff requires careful coordination and messaging strategies.

Opportunities:

- **Enhanced Media Investment:** Increasing budgets for high-impact channels like video and streaming platforms can drive greater awareness and engagement.
- **Improved Analytics Access:** Enhancing access to timely and advanced analytics tools, seamlessly integrating with our existing platforms, can provide better insights into audience behavior and campaign performance, making it easier to keep internal stakeholders informed about progress.
- **Influencer Environment Assessment:** Evaluating the influencer landscape within the education sector can help determine the potential value, if any, of influencer partnerships and guide effective resource allocation.

- **Building Target Personas to Reinforce Precise Segmentation and Targeting:** By building and leveraging Target Personas and related psychographics, we can enhance the effectiveness of our media strategies through even more accurate segmentation and targeting.
- **Opportunistic Geographic Targeting:** Implementing geographic targeting based on fluctuating local contexts enables preemptive strategy shifts that anticipate upcoming market changes.
- **Innovative OOH and Non-Digital Placements:** Exploring new and innovative out-of-home (OOH) and non-digital placements would support overall awareness and could be strong reinforcement tools for more targeted digital efforts.
- **Evolving Streaming Video Content:** Evolving streaming video to leverage relevant channels. Producing even more channel-relevant content and diversified formats.
- **Ongoing Audience Insights:** Maintaining an ongoing and regularly updated understanding of our target audiences' evolving media consumption habits and perceptions, via social listening and other tools, to inform our strategies and ensure we remain relevant.
- **Campaign Optimization:** Need for more real-time and automated optimization processes to improve the quality of conversions
- **Campaign Effectiveness:** Incorporating more campaign testing (e.g., creative A/B tests, landing page tests) for more data-driven decisions
- **Competitive:** Access to ongoing competitive intelligence (including confirmed or estimated competitive spend, share of voice, and content) to better identify opportunities and adapt to market changes.

Our ideal partner will help us address these challenges by providing innovative solutions, advanced analytics, and strategic insights that enhance our media strategies, effectively connect with our target audiences, and drive enrollment and engagement across our schools.

II. Scope of Work and Requirements

2.1 Specific Services Required*

- Paid media buying & planning
- Campaign strategy development and management
- CRM/email strategy (integration with Salesforce)
- SEO support, including recommendations to optimize our owned websites in a way complementary to our media investments.
- Performance reporting & analytics
- Competitive updates and context supporting strategy recommendations
- Design support for paid digital media, specifically production & build-out of established campaigns & designs
- Ad Copywriting

- Copy support
- Content-led paid strategy
- Google Ad Grant management
- Access to market research and/or consumer insights (whether internally generated or via contracted services, external resources)

Additionally, although not a requirement, we prefer to identify an agency partner with experience in the education and/or non-profit sectors to ensure an understanding of how to navigate the unique challenges of marketing educational services, products, and schools to families and teachers.

*Please note that if your team does not have all of these services and believes that your agency can deliver strategies and solutions to achieve Uncommon's goals, please don't hesitate to submit a proposal including insight into how your team can deliver results using an alternate set of services.

2.2 Technical Requirements

- Uncommon Schools requires the ability to access marketing performance data programmatically for integration with our internal data systems and dashboards. Internal systems include:
 - Schoolmint (Student Applicant Tracking System)
 - Salesforce (Enrollment Conversions)
 - Smart Recruiters (Staff Applicant Tracking System)
- The vendor must provide a well-documented Application Programming Interface (API) or other comparable programmatic data access method that allows for the automated retrieval of all relevant performance data, including the KPIs outlined below for ROI calculation.
- The API should offer flexibility in terms of data filtering, querying, and export formats (e.g., JSON, CSV).
- The proposal should detail or provide existing resources detailing the technical specifications of the API, including authentication methods, data endpoints, and any limitations or requirements for accessing the data.
- The vendor should outline their ongoing support and maintenance plan for the API, including notification procedures for any updates or changes that may occur.

2.3 Reporting and Analytics Requirements

- Must be capable of providing comprehensive reporting (and/or linkages to appropriate Uncommon tools such as Salesforce) that enables Uncommon Schools to assess the Return on Investment (ROI) for various marketing strategies.
- Must be able to provide necessary data in a format and frequency that allows Uncommon's internal Data & IT team to build and maintain marketing performance dashboards..
- Proposals should detail the types of data or processes available to support key performance indicators (KPIs) and how that data will enable Uncommon to conduct

comprehensive return on investment (ROI) analyses. This should include, but need not be limited to:

- For Family Recruitment: lead volume, cost per lead, cost per applicant.
- For Staff Recruitment: application volume, cost per application, and cost per hire
- Note that Uncommon would provide data to support CPH re: hiring & full-funnel data.
- The vendor should describe their methodology for **attributing conversions** (enrollment leads and applications, staff applications) to specific marketing channels and campaigns to the extent possible. This should include their approach to tracking digital conversion actions and any hard data or proxies for the impact of OOH.
- The vendor must be able to provide reporting that allows for the **segmentation of leads and conversions by target** audience (e.g., grade level for families, English/Latino audiences, role/certification for staff), marketing channel, campaign, and other relevant dimensions as agreed upon by the Organization.

2.4 Integration with Internal Teams

The selected agency must collaborate closely with our marketing, media, communications, data, technology, enrollment, and recruitment teams to align with our strategic objectives.

This collaboration may involve regular status meetings, shared planning documents, performance share-outs, or executive team updates. The agency should be comfortable integrating into existing workflows, using our project management tools, and adapting to our internal review and approval processes.

The ideal partner is expected to work closely with our internal data and technology teams as needed to access necessary resources and tools to establish systems for tracking and reporting performance. A collaborative, responsive, and solutions-oriented approach is essential for a successful partnership.

As part of your proposal, please specify the expected frequency and format of communication and collaboration with the Uncommon team (e.g., regular meetings, shared communication channels).

2.5 Project Timeline

Below is the timeline our team is dedicated to for conducting this RFP process:

High-Level Project Milestones	Date
Submit Intent to Respond	Fri, 5/9
Open session for Q&A	Tues, 5/13-Fri, 5/16

Proposal submission deadline (May 27)	Tues, 5/27
Finalists notified of presentation date	Tues, 6/10
Agency presentations	Thur, 6/12 - Mon, 6/16
Agency awarded work	Mon, 6/23
Agency kickoff & onboarding	Mon, 7/7
Campaign & media planning kickoff	Mon, 7/21
Staff Campaign Launch	Mon, 9/1
Student Campaign Launch	Wed, 10/1

2.6 Budget

Below is an approximate representation of how we allocate our approximately \$4 million paid media budget. We are sharing our current approach for context, our team is eager to explore and test adjustments to these allocations that can help our dollars work more efficiently.

Allocation of Budget by Channel		
Category	Student	Staff
Digital (Online Ads, Video Streaming, Radio, Email, etc.)	70%	100%
Out of Home	30%	0%

III. Proposal Submission Guidelines

3.1 Proposal Format

We recommend submitting your proposal as a PDF or Google Slides document that includes the following topics & content (see section 3.2).

3.2 Information to be Included in the Proposal

1. Executive Summary & Project Understanding

A brief overview of the proposal, highlighting key points and the agency's understanding of the project, objectives, and challenges.

2. Agency Background

Information about the agency, including its history, mission, and core values.

3. Relevant Experience

Relevant experience and case studies showcasing previous work in similar projects.

- Sample Campaign Plan (1-2 different clients and/or launches max)
- Creative Execution Example (visuals and copy)
- Sample Reports / Performance Dashboards
- Sample Executive Presentation
- Post Mortems/Retrospective Example

4. Proposed Approach

Describe your agency's unique approach to strategy development. In what ways do your methodologies or processes differ from traditional practices in the industry? Specifically, how will you help Uncommon Schools stand out in a crowded education sector? Emphasize any innovative techniques or perspectives that enable you to create effective strategies tailored to our needs.

- Campaign Strategy Development Approach
- Analysis & Reporting Approach
- Working / Collaboration Approach
- Performance Measurement Approach

5. Project Timeline

Provide an example of a general project timeline that outlines your proposed schedule for developing and implementing new paid media strategies for Uncommon Schools.

Include specific milestones that demonstrate your approach to onboarding, campaign planning, and execution. Indicate how quickly you can mobilize your team and resources to begin delivering results. If relevant, please break down the timeline into distinct phases, such as:

- Initial Discovery and Strategy Development
- Creative Development and Approval
- Campaign Launch
- Ongoing Optimization and Reporting

Describe your capacity to adapt the timeline based on evolving needs and feedback from Uncommon Schools, ensuring that we can move swiftly to capitalize on unexpected developments or opportunities in the sector.

6. Pricing

A detailed breakdown of agency costs and pricing approach that covers media planning, campaign management, creative development, strategy & research. Please also include how scope and campaign changes are handled. As a non-profit, having clear visibility of potential budget increases is a high priority.

7. Project Team & Bios

Information about the team members who will be involved in the project, including their roles, qualifications, and relevant experience.

8. References

Testimonials or references from previous clients to validate the agency's capabilities and performance.

9. Terms & Conditions

Any legal or contractual terms, including payment terms, confidentiality agreements, and termination clauses.

10. Appendices

Any supporting documentation, charts, graphs, if necessary.

3.3 Submission Deadline and Instructions

Final responses should be sent via email to the Uncommon client contact by **Tuesday, May 27th, 2025**, with the subject line '*Uncommon Media Agency RFP Response*'.

3.4 Contact Person for Questions

Your primary point of contact will be Suezette Weir (suezette.weir@uncommonschoools.org)

IV. Evaluation Criteria and Selection Process**4.1 Evaluation Criteria**

We will evaluate proposals based on seven key criteria:

- **Strategic Approach & Understanding**
Understanding our mission and audience.
- **Experience Across Paid Media Channels**
Proven success in various media channels.

- **Media Planning & Buying Capabilities**
Effectiveness in budget allocation and audience targeting.
- **Innovative Thinking & Creative Approach**
Ability to adapt creative assets across channels.
- **Measurement, Reporting, & Optimization**
Clear KPIs and cross-channel measurement.
- **Team Structure & Capabilities**
Expertise across multiple paid media channels.
- **Budget Transparency & Cost Efficiency**
Clear cost breakdown and flexibility in budget allocation.

4.2 Notification of Outcome

Uncommon's team will notify the selected agency partner through email and/or a scheduled live discussion.

V. Terms and Conditions

5.1 Confidentiality

Parties acknowledge that, during the term of the RFP process and any MOU, they may disclose certain Confidential Information to each other. Each Party agrees that neither it nor its employees shall disclose or use Confidential Information except as strictly necessary to perform the work governed by this process or any MOU. Each Party shall protect the other party's Confidential Information using the same standard of care it uses to protect its own confidential and proprietary information, but in any event, not less than a reasonable standard of care. This provision survives termination of the RFP process.

5.2 Right to Reject Proposals

Uncommon Schools, Inc. reserves the right to reject any or all proposals.